

“Waiting for the Barbarians” by J. M. Coetzee

[B2]

Questo acclamato romanzo del Premio Nobel sudafricano, ambientato in un avamposto di frontiera dove la paura dei barbari scatena crudeltà e ingiustizia, può essere letto come una cruda metafora dell'Apartheid.

Born in Cape Town, South Africa, in 1940, John Maxwell Coetzee is one of the world's most acclaimed English-language authors. Novelist, essayist, linguist and translator, his work explores social, political and moral issues. *Waiting for the Barbarians* was published in 1980 during Apartheid. It is set in a distant outpost of an unnamed empire where citizens live in fear of an invasion by “barbarians.” This land represents South Africa in a state of emergency due to widespread internal unrest and popular resistance.

JUSTICE

The story is protagonised and narrated by the ageing Magistrate, who lives a comfortable life dispensing justice in a hot, dusty frontier settlement. One day, Colonel Joll and his men arrive from the empire's dreaded Third Bureau. The Magistrate fears Joll, who believes in the efficacy of torture. “What if your prisoner is telling the truth,’ I ask, ‘yet finds he is not believed? [...] How do you ever know when a man has told you the truth?’ There is a certain tone,’ Joll says. ‘A certain tone enters the voice of a man who is telling the truth. Training and experience teach us to recognize that tone.’” “E se il suo prigioniero dice la verità,’ — chiedo, — ‘e tuttavia gli succede di non essere creduto? [...] Come fa a sapere se un uomo le ha detto la verità?’ – ‘C’è un tono particolare,’ – dice Joll. – ‘Un tono particolare nella voce dell’uomo che dice la verità. L’allenamento e l’esperienza ci insegnano a riconoscere quel tono.’”

CIVILISATION

Over the years, the Magistrate has built up a [convivial](#) relationship with the local fishing people, and traded with barbarian tribes who occasionally appear. Now, as Joll and his men [seek](#) evidence of a coming invasion, things are changing. Civilisation, as it was once understood in the Empire, is under threat. "It would be best if this obscure chapter in the history of the world were terminated at once, if these ugly people were obliterated from the face of the earth and we swore to make a new start, to run an empire in which there would be no more injustice, no more pain [...] But that will not be my way. The new men of the Empire are the ones who believe in fresh starts, new chapters, clean pages; I struggle on with the old story..." "Se almeno questo oscuro capitolo della storia del mondo si chiudesse qui, se questa brutta gente fosse cancellata dalla faccia della terra e noi giurassimo di ricominciare tutto da capo, di fare un impero senza piú ingiustizia né dolore. [...] Ma non è roba per per me. Gli uomini nuovi dell'Impero, loro sí che credono nelle palingenesi, nei nuovi capitoli, nelle pagine bianche. Io mi accanisco con la storia del passato..."

HUMILIATION

The Magistrate rescues a young barbarian woman, and begins a relationship with her. [Recklessly](#), he journeys into the wild and returns the woman to her people. But when he returns, Joll has gone and Mandel, a yet more menacing officer, has taken his place. Mandel arrests the Magistrate for consorting with the enemy and tortures and humiliates him. The Magistrate wants justice, but Mandel has the power: "'I am a prisoner awaiting trial [...]' But you are not a prisoner. You are free to go as you please [...] How can you be a prisoner when we have no records of you? Do you think we don't keep records? We have no record of you. So you must be a free man.'" "- Sono un prigioniero in attesa di giudizio. [...]' - 'Ma tu non sei un prigioniero. Sei libero di andare dove vuoi' [...] Come puoi essere un prigioniero se non abbiamo il tuo incartamento? Pensi che non teniamo i registri? Non c'è un fascicolo tuo, quindi devi essere libero."

THE REAL ENEMY

Eventually, the Magistrate is [released](#). When the military campaign against the elusive barbarians fails, Joll, Mandel, and the troops leave. With little food, their shops and homes [looted](#) by the departing soldiers, the [settlement](#)'s inhabitants face an uncertain future. Who is the real enemy, wonders the Magistrate, as he questions one of the soldiers: "Where is everyone else?" "Gone. Scattered. All over the place [...]" "How could it be that the barbarians did this to you?" "We froze in the mountains! We starved in the desert! Why did no one tell us it would be like that? We were not beaten — they led us out into the desert and then they vanished!" "Who led you?" "They — the barbarians!" " — Tutti gli altri, dove sono? — Scomparsi. Dispersi. Dappertutto. [...] — Un momento. Com'è possibile che i barbari vi abbiano ridotto così? — Siamo morti di freddo in montagna! Di fame nel deserto! Perché nessuno ci ha detto che sarebbe stato così? Non ci hanno sconfitti, ci hanno attirati nel deserto e poi sono scomparsi! — Chi vi ha attirati? — Loro, i barbari!"

NOBEL PRIZE

J. M. Coetzee's *Waiting for the Barbarians* won multiple awards and helped consolidate the author's international reputation. Coetzee himself wrote the screenplay for the less-successful film adaptation of the novel, [released](#) in 2019, starring Mark Rylance, Johnny Depp and Robert Pattinson. Coetzee, who [moved](#) to Australia in 2002 and became an Australian citizen in 2006, was awarded the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2003.

Glossary

- **due to** = a causa di
- **unrest** = disordini
- **convivial** = cordiale, piacevole
- **released** = uscire
- **looted** = saccheggiare
- **moved** = trasferirsi
- **outpost** = avamposto
- **dusty** = polveroso
- **settlement** = insediamento
- **dreaded** = temere
- **Bureau** = ufficio
- **seek** = cercare
- **Recklessly** = sconsideratamente